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Rereadings

Donna Tartt on *True Grit*, a modern classic of one girl's quest to avenge her father's murder

How Mattie got her man

It's a commonplace to say that we "love" a book, but when we say it, we really mean all sorts of things. Sometimes we mean only that we have read a book once and enjoyed it; sometimes we mean that a book was important to us in our youth, though we haven't picked it up in years; sometimes what we "love" is an impressionistic idea glimpsed from afar (Combray . . . madelines . . . Tante Leonie . . .) as opposed to the experience of wallowing and ploughing through an actual text, and all too often people claim to love books they haven't read at all. Then there are the books we love so much that we read them every year or two, and know passages of them by heart; that cheer us when we are sick or sad and never fail to amuse us when we take them up at random; that we press on all our friends and acquaintances; and to which we return again and again with undimmed enthusiasm over the course of a lifetime. I think it goes without saying that most books that engage readers on this very high level are masterpieces; and this is why I believe that *True Grit* by Charles Portis is a masterpiece.

Not only have I loved *True Grit* since I was a child; it is a book I loved passionately by my entire family. I cannot think of another novel — any novel — which is so delightful to so many disparate groups and literary tastes. Four generations of us fell for it in a swift coup de foudre — starting with my mother's grandmother, then in her early 80s, who borrowed it from the library and adored it and passed it along to my mother. My mother — her eldest granddaughter — was suspicious. There wasn't much over-lap in their reading matter: my gentle great-grandmother — born in 1890 — was the product of an extremely sheltered life, and a more innocent creature in many respects than are most six-year-olds today; whereas my mother (in her 20s then) kept books like *The Boston Strangler* on her bedside table. Purely from a sense of duty, she gave *True Grit* a try — and was so crazy about it that when she finished it, she turned back to the first page and read it all over again. My own middle-aged grandmother (whose reading habits were rather severe, running to politics and sci-

ence and history) was smitten by *True Grit*, too, which was even more remarkable since — apart from the classics of her childhood, and what she called "the great books" — she didn't even care all that much for fiction. I think she might have been the person who suggested that it be given to me to read. And I was only about 10, but I loved it too, and I've loved it ever since.

The plot of *True Grit* is uncomplicated, and as pure in its way as one of the *Canterbury Tales*. The opening paragraph sets up the premise of the novel elegantly and economically:

People do not give it credence that a 14-year-old girl could leave home and go off in the wintertime to avenge her father's blood but it did not seem so strange then, although I will say it did not happen every day. I was just 14 years of age when a coward going by the name of Tom Chaney shot my father down in Fort Smith, Arkansas, and robbed him of his life and his horse and \$150 in cash money plus two California gold pieces that he carried in his trouser band.

The speaker is Mattie Ross, from Yell County near Dardanelle, Arkansas, and the time is the 1870s, shortly after the civil war. Mattie leaves her grief-stricken mother at home with her younger siblings and sets out after Tom Chaney, the hired man who has killed her father. ("Chaney said he was from Louisiana. He was a short man with cruel features. I will tell more about his face later.") But Chaney has joined up with a band of outlaws — the Lucky Ned Pepper gang — and ridden out into the Indian territory, which is under the jurisdiction of US marshals. Mattie wants someone to go after him; and she wants someone who will shoot first and ask questions later. So she asks the sheriff in Fort Smith for the name of the best marshal he knows:

The sheriff thought on it a minute. He said: "I would have to weigh that proposition. There is near about two hundred of them. I reckon William Waters is the best tracker. The meanest one is Rooster Cogburn. He is a pitiless man, double-tough, and fear don't enter into his

thinking. He loves to pull a cork. Now LT Quinn, he brings his prisoners in alive. He may let one get by now and then but he believes even the worst of men is entitled to a fair shake. Also the court does not pay any fees for dead men. Quinn is a good peace officer and a lay preacher to boot. He will not plant evidence or abuse a prisoner. He is straight as a string. Yes, I will say that Quinn is about the best they have."

I said, "Where can I find this Rooster?"

Movie fans will call to mind the ageing John Wayne, who famously portrayed Rooster Cogburn on the screen, but the Rooster of the novel is somewhat younger, in his late 40s: a fat, one-

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eyed character with walrus moustaches, unwashed, malarial, drunk much of the time. He is a veteran of the Confederate Army; and, more particularly, of William Clarke Quantrill's bloody border gang, notorious in American history for the massacre at Lawrence, Kansas, and also for launching the careers of the teenaged Frank and Jesse James. Mattie runs Rooster to ground in his squalid rented room at the back of a Chinese grocery store ("Men will live like billy goats if they are let alone," she remarks, disapprovingly) and he's happy enough to take Mattie's money to ride out after her father's killer — but not to let Mattie come along.

He sat up in the bed. "Wait," he said. "Hold up. You are not going."

"That is part of it," said I.

"It cannot be done."

"And why not? You have misjudged me if you think I am silly enough to give you a hundred dollars and watch you ride away. No, I will see the thing done myself."

Mattie is not the only party

after Tom Chaney; so is a vain, good-looking Texas Ranger named LaBoeuf who has already tracked Chaney over several states. LaBoeuf (whose name is pronounced La Beef, and who is somewhat overly proud of his membership in the Rangers) wants to team up with Rooster to bring Chaney back alive and collect the bounty. But the dandy LaBoeuf, clanking along in his "great brutal spurs" and "Texas trappings", is no more interested than Rooster in allowing a 14-year-old girl to tag along on a manhunt; moreover, LaBoeuf's intent is to bring Chaney back to Texas to hang for shooting a Texas state senator in a dispute over a bird dog, a claim which Mattie hotly disputes:

"Haw, haw," said LaBoeuf. "It is not important where he hangs, is it?"

"It is to me. Is it to you?"

"It means a good deal of money to me. Would not a hanging in Texas serve as well as a hanging in Arkansas?"

"No. You said yourself they might turn him loose down there. This judge will do his duty."

"If they don't hang him we will shoot him. I can give you my word as a Ranger on that."

"I want Chaney to pay for killing my father and not some Texas bird dog."

"It will not be for the dog, it will be for the senator, and your father too. He will be just as dead that way, you see, and pay for all his crimes at once."

"No, I do not see. That is not the way I look at it."

Not surprisingly, Rooster and LaBoeuf contrive to slip away from Fort Smith without Mattie. But she strikes out after them; and as hard as they ride, they cannot lose her. ("What a foolish plan, pitting horses so heavily loaded with men and hardware against a pony so lightly burdened as Blackie!") Finally, when they cannot get Mattie to turn back, they accept her: first, in anger, as a worrisome tagalong; then, grudgingly, as a mascot and equal of sorts; and at last — as she stands among them and proves herself — a relentless force in her own right.

Like *Huckleberry Finn* (or *The*

Catcher in the Rye, or even the Bertie and Jeeves stories for that matter) *True Grit* is a monologue, and the great, abiding pleasure of it that compels the reader to return to it again and again is Mattie's voice. No living Southern writer captures the spoken idioms of the South as artfully as Portis does; but though in all his novels (including those set in the current day) Portis shows his deep understanding of place, *True Grit* also masters the more complicated subtleties of time. Mattie, having survived her youthful adventure, is recounting her story as an old woman, and Portis is such a genius of a literary mimic that the book reads less like a novel than a first-hand account: the Wild West of the 1870s, as recollected in a spinster's memory and filtered through the sedate sepia tones of the early 1900s.

Mattie's narrative tone is naive, didactic, hard-headed, and completely lacking in self-consciousness — and, at times, unintentionally hilarious, rather in the manner of Daisy Ashford's *The Young Visitors*. And like *The Young Visitors* (which is largely delightful because it views the most absurd Victorian crotchets as obvious common sense), a great part of *True Grit*'s charm is in Mattie's blasé view of frontier America. Shootings, stabbings, and public hangings are recounted frankly and flatly, and often with rather less warmth than the political and personal opinions upon which Mattie digresses. She quotes scripture; she explains and gives advice to the reader; her observations are often overlaid with a decorative glaze of Sunday-school piety. And her own very distinctive voice (blunt, unsentimental, yet salted with parlour platitudes) echoes throughout the reported speech of all the other characters — lawmen and outlaws alike — to richly comic effect, as when Rooster remarks austerely of a young prisoner he has brought back alive to stand trial: "I should have put a ball in that boy's head instead of his collarbone. I was thinking about my fee. You will sometimes let money interfere with your notion of what is right."

Mattie is often compared to her literary ancestor, *Huckleberry Finn*; but though the two of them share some obvious similarities, in